



Barriers to Implementing a Just Culture

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CSD 380 – DevOps

Module 9.2 Assignment – Establishing a Just, Learning Culture

12/7/2025

What is a 'Just Culture'?

A just culture balances organizational learning and accountability by focusing on systems, not individual blame, after safety events. It encourages reporting and learning while maintaining fair consequences for reckless behavior.



Key Barriers and Challenges

Common barriers found across studies and guidance:



Fear of punishment or disciplinary action reduces reporting



Lack of visible leadership commitment and support



Low psychological safety and distrust among staff



Insufficient training, time, and resources for investigations



Existing punitive policies and legal/regulatory pressures



Poor or cumbersome incident reporting systems



Cultural hierarchies and resistance to change

Evidence from the Literature

Selected findings from reviews and studies:



Integrative Reviews

Highlight leadership, training, open communication, and accountability as critical to implementation. (Murray, 2023).



Empirical Studies

Report fear of blame, punitive policies, and reporting failures as common obstacles. (Tasker, 2023; BMC review, 2022).



Practical Toolkits (NHS)

Emphasize psychological safety, restorative responses, and tailored interventions. (NHS England, 2023).

Barriers to Implementing a Just Culture: An Obstacle Course



Recommendations to Overcome Barriers

Practical steps organizations can take:

Leadership & Policy



Secure and demonstrate leadership commitment; model non-punitive responses



Clarify policies that distinguish human error, at-risk behavior, and reckless acts

Resources & Safety



Invest in training, reporting tools, and dedicated resources for safety work



Build psychological safety through transparency, debriefs, and restorative practices

Engagement & Alignment



Engage staff across levels to reduce hierarchy barriers and improve trust



Work with legal/regulatory teams to align accountability and learning objectives

Implementation Tips



Start Small

Pilot units and
measure changes



Use Data

Track reporting
rates, safety climate
surveys, and
follow-up actions



Communicate Wins

Share learning and
successes to
maintain momentum



Ensure Fairness

Consistent, fair
responses when
behavior is truly
reckless

References



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